

FIELD LIBRARY / ACTION CHECKLIST

Generator safety

HOME BUILDING / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Operate a portable generator outdoors at least 20 feet from doors, windows and vents, with exhaust directed away from buildings. Never run it in a home, garage or enclosed space. Use working CO alarms and never connect a generator to a wall outlet.

Do now.

☐**Choose outdoor placement**

01

Keep the generator away from occupied buildings and openings, including neighbors.

☐**Connect safely**

02

Use rated cords as instructed; a building connection requires a professionally installed transfer switch.

☐**Refuel safely**

03

Shut down and let it cool before refueling. Store fuel safely outside living areas.

☐**Check CO alarms**

04

If an alarm sounds or symptoms occur, leave for fresh air and call emergency services.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

If there is no safe outdoor position, do not run the generator. Use battery lights and ration stored electrical power for medical needs and communications. Do not improvise a connection to household wiring or operate it indoors because the weather is bad.

Watch for.

An open garage door does not make indoor generator operation safe.

People & practical needs.

Keep children and pets away from the running equipment and fuel. Check working carbon-monoxide alarms near sleeping areas

Next decision.

Read the manufacturer instructions before a crisis. Plan weather protection that does not enclose the generator or obstruct exhaust.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

SOURCES / SCOPE / LIMITS

Source-linked civilian guidance, not independent clinical or specialist certification. U.S. references; emergency numbers and services differ. Training and product instructions remain essential.

Generator safety · official guidance

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/generator-safety/>